time. There aren't all that many industries where you can make meaningful money being an employee. In most professions, there is a natural ceiling to your compensation but rightly or wrongly, in some parts of finance there really isn't. After all, how many jobs are there out there where a 20-something kid can pull seven figures and add another figure to that a few years later? Sure, it's not all that easy to land a seven-figure job, but most people are quite happy with six.

You shouldn't underestimate the value of having a salary. If you manage to get into the quant finance space, you would get paid well and get an education at the same time. You learn from people around you, from the industry and the experiences will further your personal growth, all while pulling a decent pay cheque.

One thing to keep in mind of course is that jobs in the financial industry very rarely are what those outside think it to be, and they are most certainly different from popular culture depictions. Most people with the word trader in their job title do nothing remotely similar to what hobby traders would assume, and their daily tasks involve little related to topics in a book like this. In a smaller bank, for instance, it might involve taking phone orders from an asset manager, who is buying securities on behalf of his customer. You then call up the trading desk at an investment bank, who places the actual order in the market. Neither of these industry professionals have any actual interest in any trading strategy or even outcome of this trade. They work on commissions or fixed fees.

A common perception is that a bank or financial firm will just allocate a pool of money to someone to sit around and trade as he or she sees fit. That you might be given a so-called prop book, a proprietary account, to trade with your own clever strategies. That's so rare that we could round down the number of such job roles to zero. They do exist, of course, just like there are people working full-time on building exact architectural replicas of construction projects in Lego. Working in the financial industry can be very rewarding, but to a large extent, it's just a job.

If you do aim for the type of job where you get to trade your own strategies, you might want to look at the so-called buy side. The financial industry is roughly divided into the buy side and the sell side. One way to look at this divide is that the sell side are selling financial services while the buy side buys them. Think of the sell side as investment banks, selling execution, brokerage and analysis, while the buy side is asset management, which needs